ammunition dump in Kargil, revealed Pakistan's nefarious motives. In mid-May, the Indian Army mobilized more troops from Kashmir Valley to the Kargil sector.

We were unaware of these developments, since the air force was not very involved in the earlier operations. I was oblivious to the extent of operations and the gravity of the situation in the Dras–Kargil sector. In the last week of May 1999, I proceeded on leave to Lucknow. With Delhi being a transit between my journeys from Jammu to Lucknow, I spent a few days catching up with Shivani and my other friends from college. I even forgot to pay attention to the news about the Indian Air Force losing an MiG-21 fighter jet, an MiG-27 fighter jet and an Mi-17 helicopter in the last few days of May, when these were shot down by Pakistani troops. On the last day of the month, I left for Lucknow from Delhi on a night train and reached the city in the morning. Maa and Papaji had come to pick me up. Their faces were lit up with joy; so was mine. Like a happy family reunited after a long time, we went home together.

'I've cooked rajma-chawal for you,' Maa said to me as we walked towards the main door of our house.

'I'm starving, Maa, and fed up of mess food,' I said and hugged her.

'I told her to make it,' Papaji commented playfully as he unlocked the front door.

'You only ever do everything, right?' Maa shot back. Papaji stopped midway as he swung open the door to see an envelope lying on the floor.

'Oh, the postman was here!' he said and picked up the envelope.

'What does it say?' I asked. The three of us were still at the door. Papaji's eyes narrowed as he read the address mentioned on the envelope. 'It's from . . . your unit,' he said slowly as he opened it.

I was confused, but it seemed like Maa and Papaji knew what it could be.

'It's from your adjutant. It says that you have to report back to the unit immediately,' Papaji's facial expression changed from a smile to a grimace as he said this.

'But why? My leave has just started,' I said worriedly, unhappily.

'The reason is not mentioned,' Papaji said as he handed the letter to me.